

Andrea McLean

“Spending time on yourself is *vitaly important*”

Our columnist and founder of This Girl is on Fire, Andrea McLean, tells us how to take time for yourself – without the guilt

If you were asked to list the things that stood between you and taking time out just for yourself, what would it be? Have a think...I'll wait. OK, I bet the list you came up with is short and to the point, but started with the words “I don't have the time” and rounded off with “It just feels bit, you know, selfish...”. The great news is that by the time you've finished reading this, you will have worked out that you do have time and that this isn't selfish or something to feel guilty about at all. So, let's screw the guilt part into a ball, put it in a metal bucket and set fire to it. Watch it burn! OK, now that's gone, let's move on to why it's so important.

Spending time on yourself is vitally important and something that we all need to do, like breathing, moving and brushing our teeth. Why is taking time for yourself like brushing your teeth? Well, think of it like this. You brush your teeth every day, don't you? You probably do it without thinking because it's something you've been programmed to do since you were little, and you know you need to do it because otherwise your teeth will rot and fall out. You don't brush your teeth once every six months for half a day, and think: “That was nice, and pretty self-indulgent, so that's me done now, until someone buys me a teeth-pampering day for my birthday next year.” But that's how we think about taking time out for ourselves, as a ‘treat’ that comes once in a while and involves a day at a spa or something similar. If you treated your dental hygiene like this, you'd have stinky breath and no teeth – pretty horrifying, eh? But that's what we do to our minds and bodies when we don't take the time out to look after ourselves – only we don't realise that it's our attitude that ends up stinking because we're exhausted, grumpy, demoralised and worn out.

Not only should you never feel guilty about taking time out for yourself, you should see it as a priority. We've all heard the analogy of putting on our own oxygen mask first before caring for others, right? And the analogy of pouring from an empty cup – it's impossible, you can only pour from a cup that is full

and overflowing – with love, energy and compassion. All these analogies are true, but they come from the perspective of giving to others. Right now, don't even think of spending time on yourself as a way to give you the strength and capacity to serve others – that's just another guilt suppressor and a way we use to justify why we need it. Do this for you, because you need it, regardless of anyone else!

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WHY DO YOU THINK YOU DON'T HAVE ENOUGH TIME?

I'll bet it's because you feel you have a thousand other things that you have to do that take priority. I get it; we all have balls in the air that we are juggling, from our family's needs if we are parents, to our parents' needs if we are carers, to our work needs and partner's needs. There's a lot of stuff going on and taking time out to spend on yourself can feel like just another thing to add to the list. When you feel like this, come back to the teeth-brushing analogy – do you ever not brush your teeth because you don't have time? (I really hope the answer to this is “no”). You do it anyway, right? In this instance, think about how you are spending your precious time.

DO YOU HEAR YOURSELF SAYING “YES” TO THINGS THAT YOU COULD SAY “NO” TO?

We have all done it; I used to do it all the time. Then I'd be the flaky one cancelling on the night because I hadn't wanted to go all along, but I didn't want to say so at the time. But all I'd added to my plate was a month of stress building up to it, and either an evening of guilt for letting the person down, or a day doing something I hated doing, with people I didn't want to be spending my precious free time doing it with. Neither is a good option. Just politely decline. Job done. Day or evening free.

DO YOU THINK THAT THE TIME TO SPEND ON YOURSELF HAS TO COME FROM THE “SPARE TIME” BOX?

If you do, then I'm guessing you never have any, because who does? The spare time box is always empty. That's the crazy thing about time – we are all given the same amount of it, no matter who we are or what we do. It's like a weird bank that gets a deposit every 24 hours of minutes and seconds that we must use up because we don't get them back – we all get the same fresh batch of 24 hours in every day.

DO YOU SPEND YOURS IN THE BEST WAY?

If you don't think you do, ask yourself this: “If you had an extra 15 minutes a day, what would you do with it? If you had an extra half an hour? Or an hour? What would you do with it?” You could spend it in bed and get another hour of restorative sleep a night by turning in a little earlier. It may not be actively “doing” but it still counts as taking time for yourself. What's stopping you? If it's the TV – would it hurt to switch it off a little earlier? If you like watching TV at the end of the day because it helps you relax, could you find that extra time at the start of the day by getting up half an hour earlier – before the rush of work, kids or travel? Ask yourself why you aren't doing what you would like to do, and be totally, brutally honest with yourself.



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THIS GIRL IS ON FIRE

It's my life's mission to help women feel better about themselves and that's why I started thisgirlisonfire.com. I like to call it 'a gym for the mind'. Since launching as a simple online blog in 2018, This Girl is on Fire has grown into an internationally loved personal growth brand with a simple but powerful premise: to help women think differently about themselves, their circumstances and their lives, giving them the mindset and tools to re-imagine their future. I know how it feels to be stuck, lost, afraid and broke. I know that making any kind of positive change to your life starts with the change you make to your mindset, and I want every woman to experience for themselves the emotional and financial freedom that I have found. That's why I bring together the best mentors, life coaches and motivational speakers in the world to encourage my community to think differently. It's why I promote the work of female entrepreneurs on my marketplace; to help them successfully build their brand and its awareness. It is my mission through the work we do at This Girl is on Fire and the ripple effect it has on our community, their families, friends and loved ones, to empower 100 million women and girls around the world...one girl on fire at a time.

- Health and fitness
- Family and friends
- Romance and relationships
- Fun and recreation
- Personal development
- Spiritual

to for a while, doing something different with your partner like going to a quiz night or a class (when was the last time you did something other than fall asleep in front of the TV together?), listen to an audiobook or a podcast where people talk about their lives, or on a subject you're interested in, and take five minutes a day to sit quietly in reflection.

Once you have written down the things that interest you and listed what you are going to do about them, commit to doing them. They don't get done by themselves – remember those teeth!

WRITE DOWN THE FOLLOWING:

- Today I commit to [whatever is on your list]
- I want to do this because [whatever it will help you do or feel]
- I will accomplish this by [set a deadline, otherwise you have nothing to aim for, and you'll just drift]

All of these things are time spent on yourself – and if you want to go for a spa day, that's an added bonus, not the definition of self-care! They are all things that will help you feel relaxed, stronger, more capable, rested, invigorated, loved, loving, seen and heard. Isn't that all any of us want in life? **HeW**

WRITE IT DOWN:

"I am not [doing this thing I say I want to do] because [I am doing this instead]". Then ask yourself "Why?" Why are you not doing it? Why are you doing this other thing instead? Keep going with "Why?" until you have exhausted all your answers. You will find that while all your reasons are valid; maybe you genuinely don't have much time, and you're tired at the end of the day – but the key reason is that you have got used to doing something else and you don't know where to begin to change things.

SO, WHERE DO YOU BEGIN?

Well, the good news is, taking time for yourself doesn't have to take up lots of your precious seconds, minutes and hours, unless you want it to. It can mean doing tiny little things, consistently, that make you feel good and press your own private reset button. I know that when I am doing things that I feel I am 'supposed' to do that are good for me, purely so I can tick them off and say I've done them, rather than because I enjoy them, it doesn't work at all. Your list will be different to your friend's list or your partner's list because it works for you, so don't be swayed.

To start off with, have a think about where you feel you could do with a bit more time. Things that you enjoy doing. If you're a bit stuck, try thinking about them under these headings:

These are the ones that I use. I split them into boxes, and every week on a Sunday night I write down what I want to do the following week to make me feel good in all of them. I'll be honest, some weeks are easier than others, and some weeks are so packed with other things I struggle to tick a single one off. That's OK, that's life, but the problem that most of us face is we don't factor in the time to spend on ourselves, so it disappears.

SO WHY THESE HEADINGS?

Because these are the things that make up the sum of our parts. We are all of these things – we are physical beings who were created to move around – that's why our legs get twitchy if we've sat about watching TV for too long. We were meant to be sociable, have relationships, have fun, continually grow as people and tap into the essence of ourselves, whether that's spiritually or religiously, however you like to see it. When we trudge through life, not paying any attention to these things, there will always be a part of us that feels lacking. These are the things that we need to spend time on when we think of 'spending time on ourselves' and what's great is they aren't just important, they're fun as well.

WRITE DOWN WHAT YOU COULD DO UNDER THESE HEADINGS:

They can be as simple as going for a walk, calling a friend you haven't seen or spoken



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